

Iconic Language

Word iconicity is defined as the **resemblance between form and meaning** (e.g., buzz, crash, moo, ouch), “whether the specific sounds used to form a word carry any cue about its meaning,” to put it with Waugh (1994: 55). Contrary to a long-held view that words in a language are arbitrary, recent research has shown that languages “exhibit a balance between iconicity and arbitrariness” (Winter et al. 2017: 21). “Iconicity is an important property of all languages,” write Perry et al., “a widespread property of language” (Perry et al. 2015: 1, 2). Perry et al., in their study of some 600 English and Spanish words found that adjectives were rated as more iconic than nouns and interjections were highest in iconicity, followed by verbs and adjectives. With iconicity as typically related to a sensory domain (sight, sound, touch, taste and smell), auditory and tactile words tend to be more iconic than words denoting concepts related to taste, smell, and sight. Words that carry a concrete meaning, especially if related to the senses, are also more iconic than words with abstract meanings.

Maklakova et al. (2019) have shown how J. K. Rowling, in her *Harry Potter* books, carefully chooses her words for their sound (even in chapter titles), in a masterful use of alliteration, onomatopoeic expressions, iconic vocabulary. Maklakova et al. conclude (2019: 777): “Rowling’s novels are distinguished by aesthetic excellence in her employment of the entire arsenal of phonetic stylistic devices of the English language.”

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